

From Empires to Nations: The Rise and Impact of the Modern State

Human history has always witnessed war, violence, politics, crime, and so on, but somewhere from the past, we see our modern world differently. This fosters the idea or question of where all the empires went—the greatest ones, the undefeated ones—when it all ended. For that, we must first see how empires functioned, and how they differed from our modern states. Unlike modern states, the territorial boundaries were not well defined but fixed ^[1]. Empires heavily relied on their military because they had to be in the war to sustain themselves. Pre-modern empires had the authority to govern but lacked the administrative means as ruling large areas made it almost impossible to keep uniform governance on overall land. Vast territories were home to numerous diverse groups and ethnicities under the rule of a single empire. However, these empires did not operate based on racial segregation or were not apartheid. For instance, modern Europe was dominated by “The Roman Empire” almost 1600 years ago. There were 500 more or less states in Europe, but by the 1900s there were 25 ^[2]. It took much time for the national states to dominate the political map. The idea of the absolute state originated primarily from early modern Europe, devised from the political structures of medieval feudalism. There were roughly 5 types of states at that time ^[3], which were; traditional tribute-taking empires, city-states and urban alliances (with the papacy playing a leading role), the polity of estates, the absolutist states, and the modern national states.

Early modern Europe (c. 1400-1800) experienced political, economic, and social transformations that led to modern national statecraft. And one of the major reasons was the decline of feudalism in the 15th century. Peasants gained more freedom, reducing the power of feudal lords. Kings gained greater economic and political control as feudal lords lost their grip. Eventually, monarchs took control by showing their dominance of standing armies and bureaucratic

administration. The economic theory of mercantilism was incorporated into law and a system of centralized taxation was established. While feudalism decayed, 'new' concepts and ideas emerged. At the beginning, the rulers presented themselves primarily not as feudal superiors, but as the holders of higher (non-feudal) origins, surrounded by sacred ceremonies. The transition from feudalism to centralized monarchies was a pivotal shift in history that altered all rules of governing and brought a centralized ruling system. Moreover, it was thought to manage all affairs by the state itself, so new groups were made, as a result, greater reciprocity emerged between governors and the governed, and the more reciprocity was involved, the more opportunities were generated for subordinate groups to influence their rulers. Constitutions were eventually introduced which limited the state's power in the process of government itself. One of the prominent reasons behind modern statecraft and state sovereignty was "The Treaty of Westphalia (1648)". It created the modern concept of nation-states based on sovereignty and territorial integrity.

All modern states can be classified as nation-states, each possessing defined territorial boundaries with fixed borders. Unlike earlier forms of governance, modern nation-states maintain standing armies, using force as a means of control and asserting dominance over weaker entities—an aspect that emerged only in the 19th century. Legitimacy is the right and accepted authority of a government, leader, or political regime. It is what makes a government rightful and credible, and makes people obey its laws not only in fear but because they believe it is the right thing to do. There are different forms of modern states, such as constitutional states, which are governed on behalf of a constitution and legal framework that defines the limitations of government and state rules; liberal states, which are based upon individual freedom and the rule of law with very limited government intervention; and representative democracies, where

citizens elect representatives to make decisions and pass laws on their behalf, ensuring political participation while maintaining efficient governance.

There is so much significance in the modern state system, it plays a crucial role in shaping society, politics, economics, and social structures. The modern state system provides governance structures, laws, uniform governance over all land, and a constitution. Moreover, in modern times, states also hold the national identity of their people and protect their territorial integrity. National states hold individual rights and freedom of speech of their citizens while preventing arbitrary rule and citizens from state overreach. States maintain law, order, and peace through police and military forces. Trade was often uncontrolled and there were no consistent trade standards in pre-modern times, but states established trade laws, standardized currencies, and enforced contracts to ensure fair competition. Max Weber's theory of bureaucracy and rational-legal authority explains how modern states regulate trade more efficiently than pre-modern political entities. Weber linked the rise of capitalism with structured governance. Max Weber defined the modern state as an entity that holds the "monopoly of the legitimate use of physical force within a given territory" ^[4]. However, along with its significance, there were also some disadvantages. The modern world has been shaped and driven by capitalism, particularly by British influence. Most states were established in the 20th century, and modern states are both national and racial in nature. This division gave rise to the concept of the "West and the Rest." The formation of modern states introduced various political and social structures worldwide. Today, racism persists globally, with some groups believing they are more influential or superior to others. Historical events like European colonization, segregation laws, and economic exploitation have contributed to these inequalities. Marx and Engel's views somewhat match what I have said earlier, they presented a radical critique of the state, viewing it as an instrument

of oppression rather than a protective force. They believe that the state has always been supported by cooperating monopolies, suppression of labor movements, etc. They also claimed that the state primarily serves capitalist interests ^[5]. Where areas, Thomas Hobbes (1588-1679) argues that individuals must surrender their rights to a sovereign to escape the "state of nature," which is a "war of all against all" (chaos, violence, and insecurity). But, the sovereign's power must be absolute and self-perpetuating to maintain order ^[6]. He argued that centralized authority is really important to maintain law and order, especially those with strong governments and well-established legal systems. In democratic and representative states power is often divided amongst institutions, which in Hobbes's view could lead to instability in maintaining order.

Modern states are no longer isolated entities but they operate with the interconnected world. While sovereignty remains important, economic agreements, climate treaties, and human rights conventions shape how states govern such as the World Health Organization (WHO), the United Nations Organization (UNO), and the World Bank. These international organizations play a crucial role in modern state function and relations.

The modern world has evolved from early empires and after the fall of feudal societies to structured governments and well-defined boundaries. Governments now regulate trade, enforce law, and use tools like census, social media, and technology for the security of majority and minorities. Modern societies are shaped by the functioning of the state, all of the state rules are divided for majorities and minorities, and politics all over the world has witnessed drastic changes in the time period of two centuries. Modern states are racial states and capitalist states governed by cooperates. Understanding its history helps us to see how national states work and impact our society, government, and global politics.

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